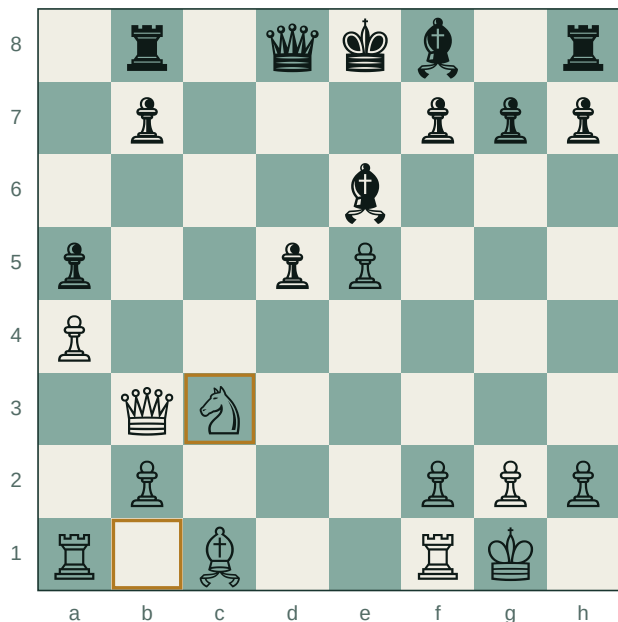


Active defensive resources: Black, move 15

Active defensive resources

Black to move



Previous move: 15.Nc3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

15...d4 16. Qb5+ Bd7 17. Qd3 dxc3

15...d4 The pawn moves from d5 to d4. The changed line means the bishop on e6 attacks the queen on b3. Recorded reply: **16.Qb5+**.

16...Bd7 The bishop moves from e6 to d7. Recorded reply: **17.Qd3**.

17...dxc3 The pawn captures the knight on c3.

At the end, nominal material is White 28 / Black 31 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +3: the balance goes from +0 to +3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A defensive puzzle may aim to preserve equality rather than win. Judge success against the threat, not only the final material count.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

The best defense may create a threat, exchange an attacker, or change the geometry of the attack. Identify the opponent's concrete idea before selecting a response.

HOW TO LOOK

Name the threatened move and the conditions it requires. Look for a move that breaks one of those conditions with tempo.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: queen on b3 and rook on a1. Check for tactical protection.